The Indians were stunned, and so were many political and military observers all over the world. What had prompted the Chinese to attack and what had caused such a short but extremely bloody and vicious war? According to Chinese records, Indian casualties stood at 4,897 dead and wounded and 3,968 captured alive. The Ministry of Defence in New Delhi puts India's losses at 1,383 soldiers killed, 1,047 wounded, 1,696 missing in action, and the same number of soldiers captured alive as the Chinese had announced, at 3,968. The PLA casualties were considerably lower, with 722 killed and 1,697 wounded, according to Chinese sources. No Chinese soldier was captured alive, which, as US military historian Larry Wortzel and Chinese scholar Cheng Feng point, out is 'a rarity in the history of warfare'.[5]

But the Chinese attack should not have come as a total surprise. Chinese encroachments into what the Indians considered their territory had begun as early as the mid-1950s. Apart from finding out, in 1957, that the Chinese had built a 179-kilometre road through Aksai Chin in the west, the first skirmishes on the Sino-Indian border occurred as early as 25 August 1959, when a Chinese patrol attacked an Indian position at Longju on the NEFA frontier. Then, on 21 October of the same year, a fire fight broke out at Kongka La in Ladakh. The first incident, at Longju, resulted in two casualties on the Indian side and at Kongka La, 17 Indian soldiers were killed in what China claimed was an act of 'self-defence'. The Indians, on the other hand, said that their troops had been subjected to 'sudden and aggressive firing' from the Chinese side.[6]

The key to understanding the origins of the 1962 War, and the conflict and rivalry between India and China, lies in taking a critical look at the writing on the sign at Bumla. Despite what it says about the 'Old Neighbouring Civilisations', which are supposed to be 'Partners in Progress', it is hard to imagine two cultures that are more different than India and China in terms of history, social structure, and political culture.

The Indian kingdoms and empires, which have waxed and waned in the subcontinent over the centuries, have always been immensely diverse, with a multitude of languages and different religions. And most of these languages have their own alphabets, all different from one another. Even today, 'unity in diversity' is what holds India together. No single religious, linguistic, or political group can claim monopoly on power, and that is why democracy has survived in India.